in all its incarnations, has played a supporting role at best. Chirag seems determined to change that. With Nitish's health and political heft apparently waning, he senses a vacuum and the chance to project himself as a leader who blends a solid caste base with the aspirations of a modernising Bihar.

One sign of Chirag's recalibrated ambition is his stated intent to contest from an unreserved constituency rather than a safer Dalit/Paswan stronghold. As a BJP insider puts it, "Chirag wants to grow the LJP beyond a caste party—to one that appeals to the youth and women." The numbers will have to reflect it, of course. In 2020, across the 135 seats the LJP contested, it lost its deposit in 110 and won just one seat. But it did pull in 2.4 million votes, with a notable 10.3 per cent vote share in those seats (5.7 per cent statewide). If one were to whittle down the arenas where the LJP has a big presence, one gets around 25 seats—precisely those the NDA might be willing to concede. But if Chirag does not settle for anything less than 30, and accounting for other allies, the domineering BJP and an ebbing JD(U) will have less than 200 seats to split between them. Easy, then, to see Chirag's utility. With the 5.3 per cent Paswan swing vote spread out, the LJP's disruption had cost Nitish 34 seats in 2020. This time, Chirag sees a larger role for himself: as successor to Nitish. What he possesses in spades is his father's perennial capacity to be the X factor. His decision to tilt, therefore, is timed to perfection. ■

Takeaways

- **Chirag Paswan to contest assembly poll, may pitch himself as a CM contender**
- **Unlike 2020, he's positioned within NDA, anticipating a post-Nitish political order**

▶ JAMMU & KASHMIR

A LANGUAGE WAR BREWS

A mandatory Urdu test for J&K revenue department jobs agitates the BJP, which cries language bias

By **Kaleem Geelani**

JAMMU AND KASHMIR was amongst the first states and Union Territories to implement the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020, but had been immune from the furore against the policy's three-language formula and the suspicion that it signified an 'imposition of Hindi'. But it couldn't stave off a political standoff over language for long—a recruitment notification for 75 Naib-Tehsildar posts on June 9, requiring a mandatory 50-mark Urdu test has spawned a controversy. A knowledge of Urdu is deemed essential for J&K revenue department jobs—it had been the only official language of Kashmir, and the region's centuries-old revenue, land and administrative records are in Urdu. However, the change in J&K's status

ANI



FAIR IS FAIR BJP supporters in Jammu protest the Urdu exam for recruitments, Jun. 10